



- Pendant pearl earrings
- Lines of curls across high forehead
- Ringlets
- Round bodice with low décolletage
- Loose, white linen billowing shift beneath



Pair of stays

CORSETS

In the 17th century finely boned garments, sometimes referred to as corsets, were worn as bodices (the visible upper part of a dress). Boned garments began to be known as *le corps* (a pair of stays). They contained tabs, which spread out to allow for the roundness of the hips. The woven silk was designed to be seen. By the 1680s this boned style had become an undergarment worn beneath the new looser styles of dress such as the mantua.

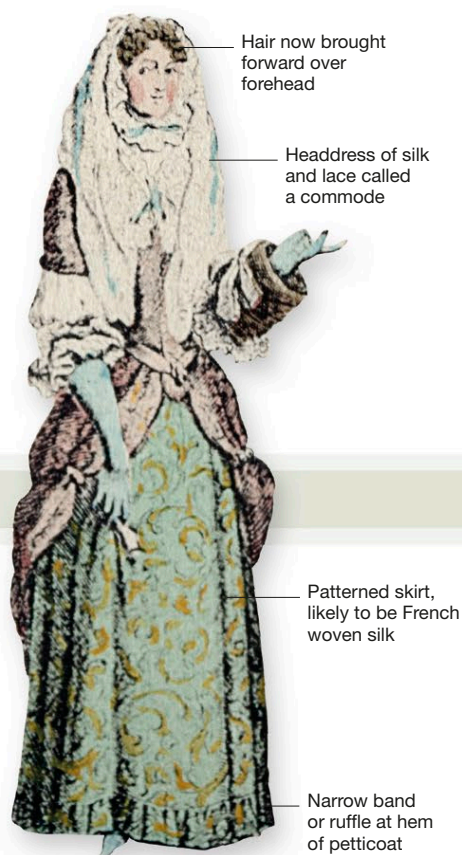
Draped silk fabric, including length of silk across one shoulder

Headdress of layers of fine silk scarves and lengths of lace

Tight curls

Fan was fashionable accessory

Artistic convention Portraits by British artist Sir Peter Lely show the drapery of 17th-century fashion, but details are indistinct. Anne Hyde, Duchess of York, wears a peach satin gown with open sleeves showing the shift underneath.



Hair now brought forward over forehead

Headdress of silk and lace called a commode

Patterned skirt, likely to be French woven silk

Narrow band or ruffle at hem of petticoat



Front-fastening bodice, worn closed

Lengthening hem

Fine silk and lace head-covering

Reverse of fabric seen at back

Woven silks Gowns and petticoats were made of matching or contrasting silks hand-woven in France and Italy on a drawloom. More subtle silk designs were being replaced by large-scale, exotic patterns, which came to be known as bizarre silks.



Elbow-length sleeves

Large-scale patterned silk

Hem with small flounce

Lace headdress Increasingly towards the end of the 17th century women wore layers of fine silk gauze and lace on headdresses. It came to be known as a commode, so-called after the wire structure that supported the towering styles.

Towards the mantua At the end of the 17th century the mantua made an appearance. It was an unstructured style with the skirts of the gown folded up at the sides and the back so that the underside of the fabric could be seen.